

Growing Okra in the Southern Garden

A heat-loving heritage crop with deep African roots

A Crop With History

Okra (*Abelmoschus esculentus*) came to the American South through the African diaspora and thrives in exactly the hot, humid summers that challenge other crops. It is a cornerstone of Lowcountry and Southern cooking, from gumbo to stewed okra and tomatoes.

Planting & Growing

- Okra loves heat — sow only after soil is thoroughly warm (late May–June in the Piedmont).
- Soak seed overnight to speed germination.
- Space plants 12–18 inches apart; full sun is essential.
- Tolerant of heat and short dry spells once established — a dependable mid-summer producer.

Harvest

- Pick pods young — 2–4 inches — every 1–2 days; older pods turn woody fast.
- Frequent picking keeps the plant producing into early fall.
- Wear sleeves — the plant's fine spines can irritate skin.

Note: Let a few healthy pods mature fully and dry on the plant if you want to save seed for next season.